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POEM – THANK YOU, M'AM

by
Langston Hughes

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About the Story

"Thank You, M'am" is a short story by the African-American writer Langston Hughes, first published in 1958. Though Hughes is best remembered as a leading poet of the Harlem Renaissance, he also wrote widely admired short fiction, and this brief, warm parable of compassion is his best-known and most frequently anthologised story. It describes a single night-time encounter in an American city between a teenage boy who tries to steal a woman's purse and the strong, no-nonsense woman who responds not with punishment, but with unexpected kindness.

Plot Summary

Exposition

Late one night, a large, strong woman named Mrs. Luella Bates Washington Jones is walking home alone, carrying a heavy purse. A teenage boy, Roger, runs up behind her and tries to snatch it, hoping to get money for a pair of shoes he wants.

Rising Action

The purse strap breaks, but the combined weight of the purse and Roger's own momentum throws him off balance, and he falls backward onto the sidewalk. Rather than running off or calling for help, Mrs. Jones grabs Roger firmly, scolds him, and insists he pick up her purse. When she asks whether he is ashamed of himself, Roger admits he only wanted money because he had none of his own. Instead of handing him over to the police, she marches him back to her own room, orders him to wash his face, and begins preparing him something to eat.

Climax

Inside her home, Mrs. Jones leaves her purse within Roger's easy reach and even leaves the door unlocked while she cooks, deliberately giving him the chance to run off with it or with money from her pocketbook if he still wants to. Roger, surprised by her trust, does not take the opportunity, and instead sits and talks with her, admitting that he only wanted the money to buy a pair of blue suede shoes.

Falling Action

As they eat together, Mrs. Jones shares a little about her own life and her own past mistakes, treating Roger with respect rather than judgment. She never calls the police or asks his name and address, choosing instead simply to treat him kindly and trust him.

Resolution

Before Roger leaves, Mrs. Jones gives him money for the shoes he wanted, but firmly warns him never to try stealing from her or from anyone else again. Roger, overwhelmed and wanting to say more than a simple "thank you," finds himself unable to express his gratitude fully. He leaves, and the story's narrator notes that Mrs. Jones never sees him again.

Character Sketches

Mrs. Luella Bates Washington Jones

A large, physically strong woman who works long hours (implied to be in a hotel beauty shop) and lives alone in a rented room. Rather than reacting to Roger's attempted theft with anger or punishment, she responds with firmness balanced by remarkable compassion, choosing to see his potential rather than only his crime. Her own admission that she, too, has "done things" she isn't proud of gives her authority as someone who understands temptation and forgiveness firsthand.

Roger

A thin, poorly dressed teenage boy who attempts to steal Mrs. Jones's purse because he wants money for a pair of blue suede shoes. Ashamed and initially defensive, he is transformed over the course of the story by Mrs. Jones's trust and kindness, showing honesty and restraint once given the chance to steal from her a second time but choosing not to.

Themes

Compassion over Punishment

The story's central idea is that kindness and trust can be more powerful teachers than punishment or judgment. Mrs. Jones has every reason to hand Roger over to the police, but instead chooses to treat him with dignity, believing this will do more to change his behaviour than any punishment could.

Trust and Redemption

By deliberately leaving her purse within Roger's reach and giving him the chance to steal from her again, Mrs. Jones offers him a test of trust. Roger's decision not to take advantage of that trust marks a quiet turning point, suggesting that being trusted can inspire someone to become more trustworthy.

Human Dignity and Connection

Despite their difference in age and their brief, unlikely meeting, Mrs. Jones treats Roger as a person worthy of respect and care rather than simply as a criminal. Their shared meal and conversation highlight the story's belief in human connection across social and generational divides.

Poverty and Temptation

Roger's attempted theft is rooted in poverty and desire (wanting shoes he cannot otherwise afford), and Mrs. Jones's own admission of her past mistakes suggests that such temptations are part of a shared human struggle rather than a simple moral failing.

Literary Devices

Characterization

Hughes reveals Mrs. Jones's character primarily through her actions and direct, plainspoken dialogue rather than through lengthy description, making her feel vivid and authentic.

Third-Person Limited Narration

The story is told from an outside perspective that stays close to Roger's experience and emotions, allowing readers to follow his shift from fear and shame to surprise and gratitude.

Dialogue-Driven Storytelling

Much of the story unfolds through natural, colloquial dialogue between Mrs. Jones and Roger, giving the story an authentic, conversational feel and revealing character through speech rather than narration.

Symbolism

The blue suede shoes Roger wants symbolise both his poverty and his very ordinary, understandable teenage desire; the purse and unlocked door symbolise the trust Mrs. Jones extends to him.

Situational Irony

It is ironic that the woman Roger tries to rob becomes the person who ultimately helps him get the very thing he was trying to steal for – money for shoes – given freely rather than stolen.

Setting

The story's urban, working-class setting – a late-night street and a small rented room – grounds its themes of poverty and everyday struggle in a realistic, relatable environment.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What does Roger attempt to do at the beginning of the story?

He tries to snatch Mrs. Jones's purse late at night, but loses his balance and falls when the strap breaks.

Q2. How does Mrs. Jones react to Roger's attempted theft?

Instead of calling the police or punishing him, she grabs him firmly, makes him pick up her purse, and takes him back to her own room to clean up and eat.

Q3. Why did Roger try to steal the purse?

He wanted money to buy a pair of blue suede shoes that he could not otherwise afford.

Q4. What test does Mrs. Jones set for Roger inside her home?

She deliberately leaves her purse within his reach and the door unlocked, giving him another chance to steal from her, to see whether he will take it.

Q5. How does Roger respond to this test?

He does not take the money or run away; instead, he stays, talks with her, and is honest about why he tried to steal from her.

Q6. What does Mrs. Jones do before Roger leaves?

She gives him money for the shoes he wanted and warns him firmly never to steal from her or anyone else again.

Q7. Why is Roger unable to properly thank Mrs. Jones at the end?

He is so overwhelmed by her unexpected kindness and trust that he cannot find adequate words beyond a simple "thank you," and the story ends with the two never meeting again.

Q8. What is the central theme of the story?

That compassion, trust, and dignity can be more powerful than punishment in helping someone change their behaviour and see their own potential.

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